

RUINSTARS

Squad Operations In A Dying Galaxy

HORDE MODE

Version 20251228



HORDE MODE

No extraction was planned. The signal was a lie, the drop zone already dead before the first boots hit ash. Now the horde is coming. Endless, relentless, testing the walls with teeth and claws and fire. Ammunition runs thin. Wounds pile up. Orders come through broken comms and half-functional consoles. Between each assault there is only enough time to drag the wounded clear, reinforce the barricades, and spend the last scraps of authority and materiel before the next wave hits harder than the last.

There is no triumph to be claimed here, only the mercy of a few stolen minutes.

THE GAME CYCLE

1. Set up battlefield
2. Deploy Player Squad
3. Start Wave 1: Spawn Horde Units (no Wave mod in Wave 1)
4. Turns
 - Start Turn
 - Roll Tactical Orders (TO)
 - Roll Turn Events
 - Activations
 - Player Squad has initiative in each Turn
 - Activate a Player Unit
 - If all Horde Units are Taken Out, Turn immediately ends
 - Activate a Horde Unit (follow its "Behavior" skill)
 - Activate next Player Unit
 - End of Turn
 - If all Horde Units are Taken Out, the Wave ends:
 - Spend MP on Upgrades (see below)
 - Roll next Wave mod
 - Spawn enemies
 - Roll Wave Objective

Horde Mode is a solo or cooperative survival mode for Ruinstars in which one Squad fights against escalating waves of enemies. Each Wave brings new threats, stronger enemies, and unpredictable battlefield events. Players must balance aggression, positioning, resource management, and emergency recovery as the enemy pressure steadily increases. The Horde never stops coming; only brief Regroup windows between Waves allow Units to patch wounds, recover supplies, and deploy defenses.

Unlike standard Missions, Horde Mode has no fixed objective beyond survival. Waves only end when all Horde Units are Taken Out, and difficulty steadily rises as the battle grinds on. Special Turn Events, supply drops, reinforcements, and Boss encounters ensure that no two runs play the same. Victory comes by finding how long your Squad can stand before being overwhelmed.

PLAYER SQUADS

In Horde mode, players deploy a normal 100GP Squad. When playing cooperatively, players may choose one of the following formats:

- **Shared Squad:**

Players share control of one full 100 GP Squad. Players take turns activating Units in that Squad.

- **Mini Squads:**

Each player deploys a reduced-size Squad:

- 2 Players → 50 GP each
- 3 Players → 34 GP each
- 4 Players → 25 GP each

Notes:

- Each mini-squad may have a Leader, but their Leader effect is ignored and each mini-squad rolls **1D3** for TO.
 - Alternatively, select one mini-squad to have the sole leader, and roll TO normally (including the Leader's **Leader** x skill). In this case, all mini-squads share the obtained TO.
- Units that are in different mini-Squads are considered to be Squadmates.

DOWNED UNITS

When a Player Unit reaches zero **HIT**, don't remove it from the battlefield. Instead, set it on its side to indicate its **Downed** status. Downed Units are ignored by Horde Units, cannot be targeted in combat, and do not take any Damage.

At the start of each Turn, Downed Units may perform a free Dash. This does not trigger an Attack of Opportunity. Downed Units don't activate during the Turn. A Standing Unit may revive a Downed Unit it Controls (**2 ACT** Mission Action): The Downed Unit returns as Standing with **1 HIT** remaining.

Whenever a Downed Unit is revived, it gains one random Injury. If that Injury is one that the Unit already has, the Unit is Deceased and removed from the battlefield.

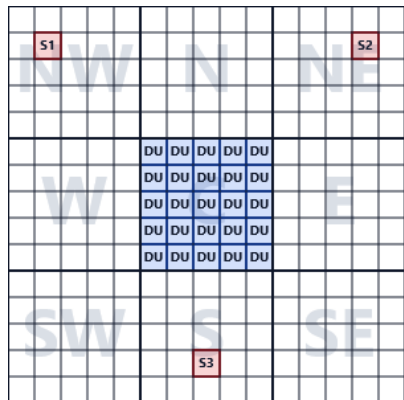
If all Player Units are Downed or Deceased, the Mission ends in failure.

BATTLEFIELDS

1 - THE WAR-TORN METROPOLIS

The city is already dead. We're just fighting over the remains. Towering shells of buildings loom overhead, their interiors gutted by fire and artillery, rebar jutting like so much exposed bone. The streets are choked with overturned transports, shattered armor hulks, and smoldering craters where something fell hard and did not get back up. Ash drifts through the air, stinging the eyes and clogging lungs, while distant fires cast a dull orange glow through the smoke. The ground itself is treacherous, cracked and unstable, threatening collapse under careless movement. And from every alley, breach, and shadowed ruin, the enemy pours in without end.

BATTLEFIELD DIAGRAM



- ☐ DU Player Squad Deployment Zone
- ☐ S1 Spawn Point 1
- ☐ S2 Spawn Point 2
- ☐ S3 Spawn Point 3

SPAWNING HORDE UNITS

For each enemy Unit indicated by the Wave table, roll 1D3 and add the Wave's Difficulty. The result indicates the Horde Unit to Spawn (see Horde Units' "Spawn" skill below). For example, in Wave 5, we will roll 5D3 (5 enemies) and add 3 (difficulty) to each result. If the results are 1, 1, 2, 2, 3, we add the difficulty to end up with 4, 4, 5, 5, 6 which maps to:

- 2 Ruin Stalkers (4, 4)
- 2 Ashline Gunners (5, 5)
- 1 Dustborn Thrall (6)

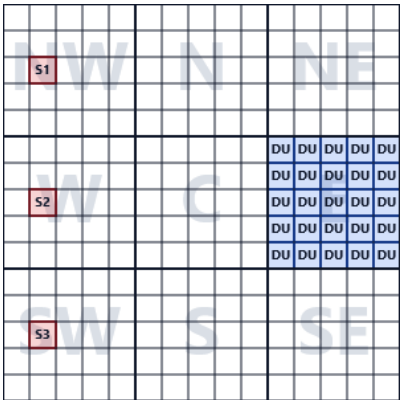
When placing Spawned Units, place the first Unit Adjacent to the first Spawn point, the second Unit Adjacent to the second Spawn point, etc. If you run out of Spawn points, just start back on the first one.

For Boss Waves, select a random Boss Unit and follow its Spawn instructions for placement and other rules. If you already fought the selected Boss in a previous Wave, re-roll until you get a Boss you haven't fought yet.

2 - WEAPONS MANUFACTURE

Long corridors stretch between sealed bulkheads and shattered blast doors, lit by flickering strips of emergency lighting and the cold glow of malfunctioning consoles. Machinery hums and grinds deep within the walls, its purpose long forgotten, while coolant leaks, sparking cables, and ruptured conduits turn every approach into a hazard. On one side, the squad digs in among barricades and overturned work platforms, watching the far end of the complex with growing dread. On the other, alarms wail and containment fields fail, and something begins to move from the depths of the Facility.

BATTLEFIELD DIAGRAM



- ☐ DU Player Squad Deployment Zone
- ☐ S1 Spawn Point 1
- ☐ S2 Spawn Point 2
- ☐ S3 Spawn Point 3

WAVE TABLE

Wave	Difficulty	Enemies	MP
Wave 1	0	5 Units	4
Wave 2	1	6 Units	5
Wave 3	2	7 Units	6
Wave 4	2	Boss + 5 Units	9
Wave 5	3	5 Units	7
Wave 6	4	6 Units	8
Wave 7	5	7 Units	9
Wave 8	5	Boss + 6 Units	12
Wave 9	6	5 Units	10
Wave 10	6	6 Units	11
Wave 11	6	7 Units	12
Wave 12	6	Boss + 7 Units	-

WAVE MODS

At the start of each Wave, before spawning Horde Units, roll **1D6** to determine a modifier for this wave.

1: Nothing

Nothing special this Wave.

2: Lull

-1 difficulty for this wave (minimum 0).

3: Surge

After spawning Horde Units for this Wave, all Horde Units perform 1 free Action.

4: Preempt

After spawning Horde Units for this Wave, all Player Units may perform 1 free Action.

5: Rage

+1 difficulty for this wave (maximum 6).

6: Clear Shots

During the first Turn of this Wave, Player Units gain +1 **ATT** on their Ranged weapons.

TURN EVENTS

At the start of each Turn, roll **2D6** to determine a special event for the Turn.

2: Second Wind

A Downed Unit returns as Standing with **1 HIT** remaining.

3: Field Dressing

One Standing Player Unit regains 1 lost **HIT**.

4: Opportunity

One Player Unit may immediately spend up to **2 ACT** on actions before the start of the Turn. This does not count as that Unit's activation for the Turn.**HIT**.

5: Supply Drop

Place 3 crates in random places on the board. If a crate lands on a Unit, immediately treat it as a "Booby Trap" crate and deal damage accordingly. Do not place that crate on the battlefield.

6: Strategic Command

Player Squad gains +2 **TO**.

7: Relentless Advance

The Horde presses on (no special event this Turn).

8: Scrambled Comms

Player Squad loses -2 **TO** (minimum 0).

9: Encroaching Threat

Each time a Horde Unit performs a Move Action during this Turn, it may move 1 additional Pace.

10: Enemy Reinforcements

Spawn **1D3+2** new Horde Units at current Difficulty.

11: Coordinated Assault

Horde Units have +1 **ACT** this Turn.

12: Overrun

All Horde Units immediately perform 1 Action according to their Behavior.

WAVE OBJECTIVES

At the start of each Wave, roll **1D6** to determine the Wave's Objective. If a Wave Objective is not completed by the end of the Wave, that Wave Objective is failed.

OBJECTIVES

1: Battlefield Control

Victory: At the end of the Wave, there is at least one Standing Player Unit on the NW, NE, SW, and SE Tiles.

2: Destroy Nexus

Setup: Place 3 Nexus markers as close as possible to the center of the West, Center, and East Tiles.

Special: Nexus Markers are items with **ARM 3** and **HIT 2** and can be targeted in combat.

Victory: All Nexus Markers Taken Out by the end of the Wave.

3: Overwhelming Force

Victory: End the Wave within 2 Turns.

4: Protect The Asset

Setup: Place an Asset marker as close as possible to the Center of a random Tile (excluding the player deployment Tile). Assets are Items with **ARM 4 HIT 4**.

Special: Horde Units will always prioritize targeting the Asset instead of Player Units in combat.

Victory: The Asset still has at least **1 HIT** at the end of the Wave.

5: Suppression Field

Setup: Place 3 Disruptor Pylons as close as possible to the center of three random Tiles.

Mission Action - Calibrate Pylon (2ACT): A Unit that Controls a Pylon calibrates it. Remove that Pylon from the battlefield.

Victory: All 3 Pylons have been calibrated.

6: The Artifact

Setup: Place 3 Search Markers in the center of three random Tiles.

Mission Action - Search (2ACT): A Unit that Controls a Search Marker searches it. Roll **1D6**: On a 1 or 2, the Artifact is found. This roll cannot be modified or re-rolled using **TO**.

Victory: The Artifact is found.

REWARDS

Once a Wave Objective's Victory condition is met, the Player Squad immediately selects one reward from the list below:

- +4 MP
- +4 **TO**. If this Wave Objective's Victory is determined at the end of the Wave, those **TO** are given in the first Turn of the next Wave, after resolving Turn events.
- One Downed Unit immediately returns to Standing with **1 HIT** remaining.
- One Standing Unit immediately gains one Spoil of War
- **1D3** Player Units perform a free Move action

PURCHASING UPGRADES

At the end of each Wave, you may spend your earned Mission Points on upgrades.

MP are gained in the following ways:

- Completing waves
- Completing Wave Objectives
- Opening a Crate and rolling "Stockpile"

UPGRADES:

- **Ammunition (2 MP):**
One Unit's Limited (**LIM**) weapon or "once per mission" ability can be used one additional time
- **Heal (4MP):**
One Unit immediately regains up to 2 lost **HIT**
- **Grenade (4 MP):**
One Unit gains a Grenade that can be used once for **1 ACT**: Throw grenade within 3 Paces. Deals 3 Ranged Damage to all Adjacent Units.
- **Medpack (4MP):**
One Unit gains a Medpack that can be used once for **1 ACT**: The Unit or a Squadmate it Controls regains **1D3** lost **HIT**.
- **Turret (6 MP):**
One Unit gains a portable Turret it can place once for **1 ACT**: Place Turret Adjacent to Unit. Player Units that Control the Turret can use it instead of their Ranged Weapon(s) when performing a Ranged Combat attack, using **ATT 4 SKL 5**. When using the Turret, draw Line of Sight from the Turret instead of the active Unit. No **ACT** penalty for multiple uses in same activation. Remove the Turret from the battlefield once it has been used 5 times.
- **Spoil Of War (8 MP):**
One Standing Unit gains one Spoil Of War
- **Reinforcements (8 MP):**
One Downed Unit returns to Standing with all its **HIT** remaining
- **Battlefield Chirurgy (8 MP):**
Remove one Injury from one Standing Unit

CRATES

Crate contents are unknown until they are opened. Crates can be targeted in combat, causing explosions dealing 3 Damage to all Adjacent Units. **ARM 3 HIT 1**.

Mission Action - Open Crate (1 ACT): A Unit that Controls a Crate opens it. Roll to determine its contents, then remove that Crate from the battlefield.

1: Stockpile

Player Squad gains +3 MP.

2: Command Uplink

Player Squad gains +2 TO.

3: Map

One Standing Player Unit may immediately perform a free Move action.

4: Relay Order

One Standing Player Unit may immediately perform a free Basic or Mission action for **1 ACT**.

5: Upgrade

Select and apply one free Upgrade of your choice (see "Upgrades" above).

6: Booby Trap

Causes an explosion dealing 3 Damage to all Adjacent Units.

HORDE UNITS

1. CARRION LEECH

ACT 2		ARM 2		HIT 2	
WEAPONS		ATT		SKL	
 Latch (2MC)		4		3	
SKILLS					
Spawn 1		Behavior			
Spawn 1: This Unit Spawns on a Roll of 1. Behavior: Horde Units can repeat the same action without incurring a penalty on its ACT cost. • If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat. • Move to be adjacent to closest enemy Unit • Move toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible • Dash toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible					
Carrion Leech 10GP				FV: 1 XP: 0	

2. TOXIN SPITTER

ACT 2		ARM 3		HIT 1	
WEAPONS		ATT		SKL	
 Claws		3		3	
 Spit Toxins (BLS 2RC)		4		3	
SKILLS					
Spawn 3		Behavior			
Toxic Aura					
Spawn 3: This Unit Spawns on a Roll of 3.					
Behavior: Horde Units can repeat the same action without incurring a penalty on its ACT cost.					
• If this Unit is Adjacent to an enemy Unit, Dash or Move away from all enemy Units. • If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat. • Move to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit • Dash to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit					
Toxic Aura: At the start of its Activation, this Unit deals 2 Ranged Damage to all Adjacent enemies.					
Toxin Spitter 10GP				FV: 1 XP: 0	

3. SENTRY TURRET

ACT 0		ARM 3		HIT 3	
WEAPONS		ATT		SKL	
 Turret (RNG4 NCV)		3		3	
SKILLS					
Spawn 2		Behavior			
Spawn 2: This Unit Spawns on a Roll of 2. Behavior: This Unit does not Activate as normal. Instead, at the end of each Player Unit activation, this Unit performs a free Ranged Combat action against the nearest enemy Unit that is a valid target. This Unit cannot perform the Melee Combat action or Attacks of Opportunity					
Sentry Turret 10GP				FV: 1 XP: 0	

4. RUIN FIEND

ACT 2		ARM 3		HIT 3	
WEAPONS		ATT		SKL	
 Bone Claws (RLT 2MC)		4		4	
SKILLS					
Spawn 4		Behavior			
Spawn 4: This Unit Spawns on a Roll of 4. Behavior: Horde Units can repeat the same action without incurring a penalty on its ACT cost. • If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat. • Move to be adjacent to closest enemy Unit • Move toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible • Dash toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible					
Ruin Fiend 20GP				FV: 2 XP: 0	

5. ASHLINE GUNNER

ACT 2		ARM 3		HIT 3	
WEAPONS		ATT		SKL	
 Fists		2		3	
 Rust Rifle (2RC)		4		4	
SKILLS					
Spawn 5		Behavior			
Spawn 5: This Unit Spawns on a Roll of 5. Behavior: Horde Units can repeat the same action without incurring a penalty on its ACT cost. • If this Unit is Adjacent to an enemy Unit, Dash or Move away from all enemy Units. • If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat. • Move to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit • Dash to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit					
Ashline Gunner 20GP				FV: 2 XP: 0	

6. DUSTBORN THRALL

ACT 2		ARM 3		HIT 3	
WEAPONS		ATT		SKL	
 Ritual Daggers (RND1 2MC)		4		4	
SKILLS					
Spawn 6		Behavior			
Spawn 6: This Unit Spawns on a Roll of 6. Behavior: Horde Units can repeat the same action without incurring a penalty on its ACT cost. • If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat. • Move to be adjacent to closest enemy Unit • Move toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible • Dash toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible					
Dustborn Thrall 20GP				FV: 2 XP: 0	

7. RAZORHOWL REAVER

ACT 3	ARM 4	HIT 4	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Hooked Cleaver (2MC)		4	5
SKILLS			
Spawn 7		Behavior	
Spawn 7: This Unit Spawns on a Roll of 7.			
Behavior: Horde Units can repeat the same action without incurring a penalty on its ACT cost.			
• If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat. • Move to be adjacent to closest enemy Unit • Move toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible • Dash toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible			
Razorhowl Reaver 30GP		FV: 3	XP: 0

8. GRAVEWARD SENTINEL

ACT 3	ARM 4	HIT 4	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Scrap Shiv		3	3
 Grave Cannon (BLS 2RC)		4	5
SKILLS			
Spawn 8		Behavior	
Spawn 8: This Unit Spawns on a Roll of 8.			
Behavior: Horde Units can repeat the same action without incurring a penalty on its ACT cost.			
• If this Unit is Adjacent to an enemy Unit, Dash or Move away from all enemy Units. • If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat. • Move to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit • Dash to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit			
Graveward Sentinel 30GP		FV: 3 XP: 0	

9. LAST-LIGHT EXECUTIONER

ACT	3	ARM	4	HIT	4
WEAPONS				ATT	SKL
 Judgement Axe (RLT CHR1 2MC)				4	5
SKILLS					
Spawn 9			Behavior		
Spawn 9: This Unit Spawns on a Roll of 9. Behavior: Horde Units can repeat the same action without incurring a penalty on its ACT cost. • If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat. • Move to be adjacent to closest enemy Unit • Move toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible • Dash toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible					
Last-Light Executioner 30GP					
				FV: 3	XP: 0

10. BOSS: SHADOW STALKER

ACT	4	ARM	4	HIT	8
WEAPONS				ATT	SKL
 Twilight Blades* (2MC BLD1)				4	5
SKILLS					
Boss Spawn		Behavior			
Phasebound		*Twilight Blades			
Counter					
Boss Spawn: This Unit spawns as far as possible from any enemy Units, not visible, or at least in Cover.					
Behavior: Horde Units can repeat the same action without incurring a penalty on its ACT cost.					
Each time this Unit moves, if there is at least one non-visible enemy Unit, place this Unit Adjacent to a random non-visible enemy. If all enemies are visible, this Unit moves normally.					
• If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat. • Move toward a random non-visible enemy Unit (if any), to cover if possible • Move toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible • Dash toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible					
Phasebound: This Unit is always considered to be in Cover.					
Counter: Each time this Unit is the primary target of a Melee Attack, if this Unit did not lose any HIT by the end of that Combat, it may immediately perform a Melee Attack against the original Attacker.					
Twilight Blades: Each time this Unit uses its Twilight Blades in combat, if the Target is the only enemy Unit that can see this Unit, its Twilight Blades gain RND1 (Rending 1)					
<i>The Shadow Stalker is rarely seen until it strikes, slipping through light and shadow with unnatural precision. It never lingers on a single target, vanishing after each attack and reappearing elsewhere in a calculated pattern of violence. By the time its prey can react, it has already moved on.</i>					
Boss: Shadow Stalker 50GP		FV: 5 XP: 0			

11. BOSS: OSSUARY ENGINE

ACT 4	ARM 4	HIT 8	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Bonegrind Actuators (RLT)		4	5
 Hull Breach Cannon (BLS 2RC)		4	4

SKILLS

Boss Spawn	Behavior
Null Construct	

Boss Spawn: This Unit spawns as close as possible to the center of a random tile. All Adjacent enemies immediately take 2 Melee damage.

Behavior: Horde Units can repeat the same action without incurring a penalty on its ACT cost.

- If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat (once per activation)
- If this Unit is Adjacent to an enemy Unit, Dash or Move away from all enemy Units
- If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat.
- Move to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit
- Dash to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit

Null Construct: This Unit cannot be targeted in Ranged combat if it has all of its HIT.

The Ossuary Engine advances with grinding inevitability, a towering fusion of dead machinery and ossified flesh. Layers of bone and corroded plating absorb incoming fire until something vital is breached. When it finally bleeds, sparks and marrow spill together as the Engine responds with cold, methodical force.

Boss: Ossuary Engine 50GP

FV: 5 XP: 0

12. BOSS: BROODMIND

ACT 4	ARM 4	HIT 8	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Claws (RND1 2MC)		4	5
 Spew (BLS)		4	4

SKILLS

Boss Spawn	Behavior
Slow	Nutrient Lash
Spawn Sacs	

Boss Spawn: This Unit spawns as close as possible to the center of the center tile. All Adjacent enemies immediately take 2 Melee damage.

Behavior: Horde Units can repeat the same action without incurring a penalty on its ACT cost.

- If there are no Adjacent enemy Units, spawn one Carrion Leech Adjacent to this Unit (once per activation)
- If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat.
- If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat
- Move away from all enemy Units, to cover if possible
- Dash away from all enemy Units, to cover if possible

Slow: Each time this Unit performs the Move action, it only moves 1 Pace.

Spawn Sacs: Each time this Unit is the target of melee combat and does not lose any HIT as a result of that combat, spawn one Carrion Leech Adjacent to it.

Nutrient Lash: Each time any enemy Unit within 3 Paces loses 1 or more HIT in melee combat, roll 1D6. On a 1 or 2, this Unit regains 1 lost HIT.

The Broodmind dominates the battlefield through sheer biological excess, its swollen mass spawning lesser horrors in an endless tide. It does not rush the fight but overwhelms it, filling every gap with living weapons guided by a single, oppressive will. Left unchecked, it turns survival into a war of attrition that cannot be won.

Boss: Broodmind 50GP

FV: 5 XP: 0